Query Performance Prediction Is Not Benefit Prediction: Observability for Selective Retrieval Interventions

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Abstract

Query performance prediction (QPP) estimates whether a ranking is poor, but selective retrieval needs a different prediction: whether an intervention will improve it. We formalize this distinction as a decision under observable telemetry and derive an exact, cost-aware decomposition of the gain that no policy intervening only on failing queries can reach. We evaluate LLM query expansion, cross-encoder reranking, and pseudo-relevance feedback on six benchmarks, four of them pre-registered and untouched. Without a budget cap, a perfect failure gate recovers only 8–57% of the oracle's gain. On the same queries, the learned failure gate detects failure far better than it predicts benefit, a gap confirmed as a pre-registered prediction on three untouched test sets (AUC differences +0.20 to +0.33). The reason is reachability: reranking rescues a failing query only when a relevant document sits below the top ten, and the gate's score does not see whether one does (AUC 0.27–0.53). How much a failure score helps routing depends on the corpus: near random on five corpora, but useful on HotpotQA, where benefit grows with difficulty, against our pre-registered prediction. Stronger pre-action predictors and partial probes help inconsistently. Selective retrieval should be evaluated by intervention benefit, oracle headroom, and cost-aware routing, not by failure-prediction accuracy alone.

1 Introduction

Retrieval interventions help some queries and harm others. LLM query expansion (QE) can rewrite a query using the evidence it retrieves [16], yet it harms a measurable fraction of queries [1, 29]; cross-encoder reranking and pseudo-relevance feedback (PRF) are equally uneven. The natural response is to intervene selectively, and the natural gate is a query performance predictor (QPP): intervene when the current ranking looks like it is failing [2, 12]. That the gate's target differs from the quantity a policy needs is not new: selective-QE work predicts expansion benefit directly [7], and uplift modelling shows that targeting high-risk cases is not targeting the cases a treatment helps [3, 9]. What is missing is how much a failure gate gives up, why, and whether the telemetry a deployed system can observe, its *observability*, can do better.

Contributions. (C1) A decision framing of selective intervention under observable telemetry, with an exact decomposition of the gain no policy acting only on failing queries can capture, at zero and positive cost (Section 3). **(C2)** Evidence on six corpora, four pre-registered and untouched, that the targets differ and that the difference has measurable consequences: the uncapped *failure-only ceiling* is 8–57% of the oracle's gain, and failure scores rank helped queries far below how they rank failing ones. **(C3)** A mechanism, reachability, that explains why the gate selects poorly among failing queries, and pre-registered tests of when a failure score, stronger pre-action predictors, or partial probes improve routing: on some corpora, not on others.

2 Related Work

QPP and selective QE. Pre- and post-retrieval QPP (Clarity [6], WIG [33], NQC [23]) predicts query difficulty. Cronen-Townsend et al. [7] compare the clarity of expanded and unexpanded rankings; Amati et al. [2] gate expansion on difficulty predictors; Lv and Zhai [17] predict a feedback weight; Collins-Thompson [5] trades reward against risk. Even idealised selective QE needs QPP at Kendall $\tau \geq 0.5$ [11], and Chifu et al. [4] analyse where QPP fails and what that implies for selective query processing. Such work sizes predictor accuracy or evaluates gated systems; to our knowledge none bounds what a failure gate can recover, explains its selection error, or compares gates at matched budgets.

LLM QE and adaptive retrieval. Query2doc [28], MuGI [32], and CSQE [16] expand unconditionally; generative expansions often hurt strong retrievers [29] and fail on unfamiliar or ambiguous queries [1]. Kotte [13] gates prompt-only rewriting for dense retrievers without reliable gain. Sarode [21] finds that a learned selector over candidate LLM rewrites captures little oracle headroom and transfers inconsistently; we ask whether to intervene at all, across three interventions, and bound failure-restricted policies. Adaptive-RAG [12] routes on question complexity and Mallen et al. [19] retrieve only for less popular entities; cascade rankers [27] spend costly stages only on promising candidates, and cutoff and efficiency predictors [8, 25] set per-query reranking depth or pruning. In uplift terms [9], both outcomes are observed offline, so our label is exact up to relevance noise.

3 Framework

For a query q, let R_0 be the original ranking and R_a the ranking after intervention a, with metric M (nDCG@10). The intervention's effect is $\Delta_a(q) = M(R_a, q) - M(R_0, q)$ and its cost c_a ($\Delta_0 = c_0 = 0$). With full information the best decision is $a^*(q) = \arg\max_a\{\Delta_a(q) - \kappa c_a\}$, for a cost weight κ. A deployed controller sees only telemetry Z, so the best it can do is $\pi^*(Z) = \arg\max_a\{\mathbb{E}[\Delta_a \mid Z] - \kappa c_a\}$. What matters is therefore what Z reveals about Δ_a, not about $M(R_0)$. Two information sets differ in cost: *pre-action* telemetry Z_0 describes R_0 and costs no intervention, though computing it is not free; *post-action* telemetry Z_1 also describes R_a and exists only after c_a is paid. A *probe* observes part of the intervention, such as cross-encoder scores of a few candidates, at part of its cost (Section 9). A failure gate replaces $\mathbb{E}[\Delta_a \mid Z_0]$ with $P(F \mid Z_0)$, where $F = \mathbf{1}[M(R_0, q) = 0]$.

The failure-only ceiling. Fix one intervention with $c_a = 1$, so κ is its cost per query in nDCG@10 units. The oracle selector earns $G_{\text{orc}}(\kappa) = \mathbb{E}[(\Delta - \kappa)_+]$. A policy that may act only on failing queries does best by intervening where $F = 1$ and $\Delta > \kappa$, earning $G_F^*(\kappa) = \mathbb{E}[F(\Delta - \kappa)_+]$ (the *failure-restricted oracle*; its share of G_{orc} is the failure-only ceiling), so

$$G_{\text{orc}}(\kappa) - G_F^*(\kappa) = \mathbb{E}[(1 - F)(\Delta - \kappa)_+]$$

(gain on healthy queries) bounds every failure-restricted policy at any $\kappa \geq 0$. Because $M \geq 0$, a failing query cannot be harmed ($\Delta \geq 0$ when $F = 1$), so at $\kappa = 0$ a *perfect* failure gate, intervening iff $F = 1$, attains G_F^*. At $\kappa > 0$ it earns $G_F(\kappa) = \mathbb{E}[F(\Delta - \kappa)]$, a further $\mathbb{E}[F(\kappa - \Delta)_+]$ below G_F^* spent on failing queries helped by less than κ, which only information beyond the binary label avoids. The identity is elementary; its use is that every term is measurable offline for any intervention. It does not bound a policy built from a failure *score* that also acts on healthy queries.

4 Setup

Data. TripClick [20]: 1.52M health documents, the TAIL bucket's validation and test splits (1,175 queries each), with click-derived relevance labels. BEIR NQ [14, 24]: 2.68M passages, human labels; 800 validation and a disjoint 2,052-query test set. BEIR ArguAna [26]: 8,674 arguments, 1,406 queries whose relevant document is the counterargument; BEIR FiQA [18]: 57,638 financial posts; BEIR DBPedia-Entity [10]: 4.63M entities, 400 test queries with graded labels; BEIR HotpotQA [31]: 5.23M passages, 7,405 multi-hop test questions (Section 8).

Interventions. *LLM QE*: BM25 over SQLite FTS5; a deterministic rule picks one of four expansion operators or none, and `qwen2.5:3b` (4-bit, greedy, ≤ 2 calls) writes a corpus-grounded expansion. On TripClick and under dense retrieval (`bge-small-en-v1.5` [30]) the expanded ranking's top candidates are reranked by a MiniLM cross-encoder [22]; the original is not, so those labels include the reranker's effect. TripClick's deployed QE fuses original and expanded rankings (RRF); NQ's uses the expanded ranking. *Reranking*: the cross-encoder scores the BM25 top 100; its top 50 lead. *PRF*: RM3-style [15] weights from the top d documents select t terms whose BM25 ranking is interpolated with the original (weight λ); (d, t, λ) is tuned on validation over 108 settings.

Labels and models. *Failure*: $F = 1$ (45% of TripClick and 49% of NQ test queries under BM25). *Harmed*: $\Delta < 0$, ties not harmed. Detection is a logistic regression on 8 pre-action features (score shape, term coverage, rare-term IDF, entity overlap, coherence, perturbation stability; 6 under dense). Action utility is fit on Δ from post-action features. For pre-action routing, a *benefit* model regresses Δ on the 8 pre-action features alone. Three further benefit predictors, pre-registered for ArguAna (Section 8), use 10 pre-action features (the 8 above, NQC, query length), as does the failure gate on ArguAna and FiQA: B1, LightGBM regression on Δ; B3, LightGBM quantile regression; and B2, the distance-weighted mean Δ of the k nearest training queries under frozen `bge-small-en-v1.5` embeddings. Every model and threshold is fit on validation and scored once on test; intervals are paired bootstraps over queries (10^4 resamples). We call the deployed detector, used to route, the *learned failure gate*, and any model of Δ a *benefit predictor*.

Evidence ledger. Only the ArguAna, FiQA, DBPedia, and HotpotQA results (Section 8) are independent confirmation: every NQ query and the TripClick TAIL test set have been inspected. *Fixed before a test run*: the NQ, reranking, and PRF runs. *Pre-committed analyses of inspected traces*: the detection and harm AUCs, ceiling, budget routing, and Holm correction. *Exploratory*: TripClick test was used during development, the changed-query harm comparisons were added after seeing the main results, and the NQ B1/B2 runs, diagnostics, probes of Section 9, and the reachability analysis on the first four corpora followed protocols frozen before computing but after the test sets were inspected; analyses added after review are marked in the text. Pre-commitments and scripts are in the anonymized repository: https://anonymous.4open.science/r/agentic-query-expansion-8939/.

Table 1: Failure-only ceiling (test). Rescue: $P(\Delta > 0 \mid F)$. Healthy helped / harmed: $P(\Delta \gtrless 0 \mid \neg F)$. Share: perfect failure gate's gain over the oracle's at $\kappa = 0$, 95% CI. Below the first rule: pre-registered, untouched test (n = 430, 648, 400, 7,405).

Setting	$P(F)$	Rescue	Healthy help	harm	Share
LLM QE, TripClick	.45	.07	.15	.19	42% [32, 52]
LLM QE, NQ	.49	.07	.19	.33	33% [26, 40]
LLM QE, TripClick, dense	.59	.06	.25	.41	34% [25, 43]
LLM QE, NQ, dense	.26	.15	.19	.29	33% [27, 40]
Reranking, TripClick	.45	.17	.24	.56	52% [44, 60]
Reranking, NQ	.49	.46	.55	.19	57% [54, 60]
PRF, TripClick	.45	.01	.12	.20	8% [1, 17]
PRF, NQ	.49	.05	.20	.22	32% [25, 39]
Reranking, ArguAna	.21	.36	.25	.53	38% [27, 49]
PRF, ArguAna	.21	.01	.05	.06	18% [0, 52]
LLM QE, ArguAna	.21	.27	.23	.59	39% [27, 52]
Reranking, FiQA	.51	.29	.52	.23	46% [39, 53]
PRF, FiQA	.51	.02	.14	.19	28% [11, 46]
Reranking, DBPedia	.22	.58	.77	.17	21% [15, 28]
Reranking, HotpotQA	.11	.61	.43	.11	25% [23, 27]

5 The Failure-Only Ceiling

Failure-restricted policies miss most of the gain. The failure-restricted oracle captures 8–57% of the oracle's gain (Table 1; 18–46% on ArguAna and FiQA), though it never makes a query worse; the lowest shares, and the widest intervals, come from PRF, which barely acts. The share follows how often an intervention rescues a failing query relative to how often it helps a healthy one: reranking rescues 17–46% of failing queries, so up to half its headroom lies there; LLM QE rescues 6–15% and PRF almost never. The rest sits in healthy queries the intervention also often harms, which only benefit prediction can separate. At a per-query cost of 0.02 the shares are similar (8–57%; 22–47% on ArguAna and FiQA), and intervening on every failing query then loses outright for PRF and dense TripClick QE.

A budget cap loosens the restriction only where rescues are common (exploratory, post-review). At a 10% cap, failing queries hold 54–98% of the capped oracle's gain for reranking and ArguAna QE (83% on FiQA); the other settings stay near their uncapped shares.

The learned failure gate also selects poorly. At a 10% budget, 35–80% of its picks are failing queries (the rest are healthy), and it realises at most 34% of the capped failure-restricted oracle's gain, and its gain is negative in five settings (all three on ArguAna) and in 7–9 of 11 at 25–75%. Among failing queries its score ranks the rescued ones no better than chance (Table 2; below it in four settings, not on FiQA). At a 25% budget, 45–68% of its picks on TripClick and NQ (30–36% on ArguAna) are failing queries the intervention leaves unchanged (exploratory).

Table 2: One score, two targets (test). Failure: AUC of the learned failure gate's score for F. Helped: its AUC for $\Delta > 0$ on the same queries, 95% CI. Within failing: helped AUC among failing queries (–: fewer than 20 rescued). Failure is shared by the interventions on a corpus and retriever. Exploratory except the last four rows (pre-registered).

Setting	Failure	Helped	Within failing
LLM QE, TripClick	0.65	0.52 [0.46, 0.57]	0.47
LLM QE, NQ	0.68	0.50 [0.46, 0.53]	0.44
LLM QE, TripClick, dense	0.64	0.50 [0.45, 0.54]	0.51
LLM QE, NQ, dense	0.69	0.56 [0.53, 0.59]	0.50
Reranking, TripClick	0.65	0.47 [0.43, 0.51]	0.44
Reranking, NQ	0.68	0.48 [0.46, 0.51]	0.37
PRF, TripClick	0.65	0.49 [0.42, 0.55]	–
PRF, NQ	0.68	0.45 [0.41, 0.48]	0.34
Reranking, ArguAna	0.65	0.43 [0.37, 0.49]	0.34
PRF, ArguAna	0.65	0.54 [0.39, 0.68]	–
LLM QE, ArguAna	0.65	0.42 [0.36, 0.48]	0.36
Reranking, FiQA	0.72	0.52 [0.47, 0.57]	0.56
PRF, FiQA	0.72	0.46 [0.37, 0.54]	–
Reranking, DBPedia	0.76	0.43 [0.36, 0.49]	0.48
Reranking, HotpotQA	0.89	0.64 [0.63, 0.66]	0.37

The ceiling and the selection error are separate constraints, and both operate at every budget below 100%.

6 Detection vs. Benefit

The failure gate detects failure, not benefit. The learned failure gate ranks failing queries at AUC 0.64–0.69 (Table 2), ordinary QPP accuracy: NQC [23] reaches 0.647 on TripClick and 0.721 on NQ. Scored against whether the intervention helps (exploratory, post-review), the same scores reach only 0.42–0.56, with intervals below 0.5 for NQ PRF and ArguAna QE and reranking and above only for dense NQ QE. Pre-registered on FiQA, DBPedia, and HotpotQA, the gap replicates in every setting (Holm $p < 0.001$; Section 8), and Figure 1 shows its shape.

Benefit predictors do better but are weak (helped AUC $\leq$ 0.58; NQ probe 0.65, HotpotQA B1 0.67 and probe 0.73). They beat the failure score on NQ reranking (+0.08 to +0.17, probe largest), NQ PRF, and ArguAna QE and reranking (+0.07 to +0.12); elsewhere differences span zero, except that the linear model trails it on TripClick PRF (−0.06).

The detector's lead over harm prediction does not contradict this. Detection beats harm AUC by +0.02 to +0.33 (Holm-significant in seven of eight original settings; +0.22 and +0.20 on FiQA), but failing queries cannot be harmed and are mostly unchanged, so the harm label is largely a failure indicator; on changed queries the gap vanishes in every TripClick and NQ BM25 setting (table in the repository).

Why: reachability (exploratory on the first four corpora, protocol frozen before computing; pre-registered on DBPedia and HotpotQA). Reranking reorders the BM25 top 100, so it can rescue a failing query only if a relevant document sits at ranks 11–100. No failing query without one is helped, on any of the six corpora, while 29–88% of those with one are. The gate's score, built from the top of the ranking, does not find these *reachable* failures: its AUC for reachable among failing queries is 0.27–0.53 (0.40 [0.27, 0.54] and 0.37 [0.33, 0.41] pre-registered), and among reachable failures the helped rate shows no consistent trend across its tertiles. Among healthy queries, harm concentrates where the first relevant document is already at rank 1 (mean Δ −0.02 to −0.35 on the first four corpora).

7 Routing at Matched Budgets

Pre-action routing. At every budget (10–75%), each scorer that decides before intervening stays close to random routing and far below the oracle on TripClick, NQ, and ArguAna (table and cost curves in the repository). Failure routing beats random by at most 0.006 at any budget and often falls below it, and at a 25% budget each pre-action scorer's picks are helped within −0.11 to +0.08 of the base rate. Averaged over budgets, NQC is no better than the detector, and benefit routing beats failure routing only for reranking on NQ (+0.009 [+0.003, +0.015]), where it leads at every budget (per-budget CIs in the repository). Boosted and embedding predictors (B1, B2), fit on NQ validation (exploratory), do no better: none survives Holm, and the best recovers 8% of the oracle-minus-failure headroom. Failure routing can still save cost: for LLM QE on NQ, the failure-selective policy halves generator calls and recovers most of unconditional QE's loss (+0.015).

8 Pre-Registered Replications

ArguAna. *Question:* do stronger pre-action benefit predictors beat failure routing on data never inspected for this work? *Design*, pre-registered before download (`configs/arguana_precommit.json`): a debate-grouped split (701/275/430), the three interventions (LLM QE as on NQ), and Holm-corrected primary contrasts for B1–B3 (B3's registered quantile choice is unsound, so a secondary B3 fixes 0.25); leakage fixes were dated amendments before any label was read. *Result: no.* Every intervention loses on average (reranking −0.071 [−0.108, −0.034], LLM QE −0.163), yet the oracle could gain 0.053 and 0.010 budget-averaged, so the task is pure selection. For reranking, B1 minus failure routing is +0.015 [−0.001, +0.028] (Holm $p = 0.13$), B2 minus failure +0.008 (Holm $p = 0.37$), B3 minus B1 under a budget cap +0.006 ($p = 0.52$); the best recovers 16% of the oracle-minus-failure headroom, below the pre-registered 25% bar, and a secondary family agrees (none of nine survives Holm). Failure routing of reranking is below random at every budget. PRF changes only 9% of rankings, so its rows are uninformative. At 430 queries, B1's +0.015 may be real but is unresolved.

FiQA. *Predictions*, fixed before download in `configs/fiqa_precommit.json`: (P1) the failure score ranks failure better than benefit; (P2) among failing queries it ranks the rescued ones below chance; (P3, P4) since reranking helps on validation (+0.10), Probe-10 routing beats failure and B1 routing. Reranking and PRF follow the ArguAna protocol (1,500 training, 500 dev, 648 test queries; one Holm family, five evaluable tests). *Confirmed:* failure detection does not translate into benefit prediction (P1: 0.72 against 0.52 and 0.46, Holm $p < 0.001$). *Not confirmed:* the within-failing inversion (0.56 [0.49, 0.63]; PRF, with 8 rescues, not evaluable) and the probe (minus failure −0.001 [−0.009, +0.008], minus B1 +0.006 [−0.001, +0.013]; Holm $p \geq 0.25$). B1 and B2 do not beat failure routing either (−0.006 each, Holm $p = 0.19$).

DBPedia and HotpotQA. *Question:* on new data, does the failure score carry routing information, and is any shortfall specific to

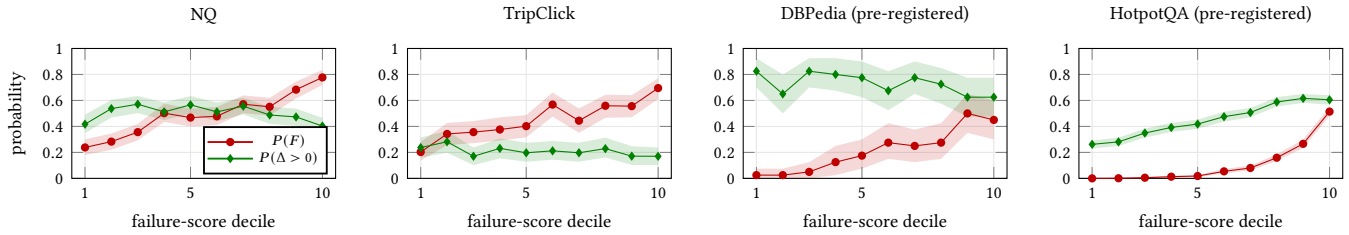


Figure 1: One score, two targets (reranking, test, 95% bootstrap bands). By decile of the learned failure gate's score, the failure rate rises steeply; the share of queries reranking helps stays flat or falls on NQ, TripClick, and DBPedia but rises on HotpotQA. NQ, TripClick: exploratory.

Table 3: Pre-registered tests on DBPedia and HotpotQA (reranking, test; one Holm family per corpus). S: learned failure gate's score. P2–P4: exact-budget calibrated routing, averaged over 10–75% budgets. Bold: against the prediction.

Test (prediction)	DBPedia	HotpotQA
P1 $\mathrm{AUC}_F - \mathrm{AUC}_{\Delta>0}$ (> 0)	+0.33 [0.24, 0.42]	+0.24 [0.23, 0.26]
P2 S − random (n.s.)	+0.001 [−0.002, 0.013]	**+0.023** [0.021, 0.025]
P3 B1 − S (n.s.)	+0.003 [−0.009, 0.011]	**+0.003** [0.002, 0.005]
P4 Probe-10 − S (> 0)	**+0.002** [−0.009, 0.011]	+0.008 [0.007, 0.010]
P5 AUC reachable (≤ 0.6)	0.40 [0.27, 0.54]	0.37 [0.33, 0.41]

QPP? *Predictions*, fixed before download (`configs/info_value_precommit.json`), were built to let the account 'pre-action scores carry little routing information' fail: it fails if routing on S beats random (P2) or B1 beats S (P3); reachability fails if S separates reachable from unreachable failing queries (P5). DBPedia's 400 test queries are scored by five-fold cross-fitting; HotpotQA uses 1,500 training and 500 dev queries. *Result* (Table 3): the detection–benefit gap (P1) and reachability (P5) hold on both. Routing splits. DBPedia behaves as predicted, except that the probe does not help. On HotpotQA, against the prediction, S beats random by +0.023 and B1 and the probe beat S (Holm $p < 0.001$): there, reranking helps more the higher the failure score (Figure 1), so ranking by difficulty is partly ranking by benefit, though not within failing queries (P5). Without a budget cap no score beats always reranking on either corpus (mean Δ +0.13, +0.12). PRF barely acts (mean Δ −0.003, +0.003).

9 Partial Observation and Cost

A probe sits between pre- and post-action telemetry. In an exploratory analysis (protocol frozen before computing), we score only the first $k \in \{5, 10, 20\}$ BM25 candidates ($k = 10$ primary, fixed in the protocol) with the cross-encoder, regress the Δ of full reranking on nine probe features with B1's model and selection rule, and fully rerank the top-scoring queries, reusing the probe's scores. Each policy is charged its median measured latency (50 validation queries per corpus): full reranking takes 0.48, 1.11, 1.26, and 0.84 s on NQ, TripClick, ArguAna, and FiQA, a ten-candidate probe 0.05–0.13 s.

On NQ, where reranking usually helps, the Probe-10 policy beats failure routing by +0.024 [+0.017, +0.031] and B1 by +0.017 [+0.011, +0.022] over 10–75% reranked (both Holm-significant), and its predictions rank Δ best (Spearman 0.25). NQ's pre-action telemetry (a perturbation search over 2.68M passages) takes longer than reranking every query, so always reranking dominates failure and B1 routing; against free NQC (post-review), probe routing gains +0.020 [+0.012, +0.028] at equal median-latency cost. Probes do not help on TripClick and ArguAna, where reranking loses on average, nor on FiQA or DBPedia; they do on HotpotQA (Section 8).

10 Discussion and Limitations

QPP and selective retrieval predict different targets, and the difference matters. One consequence is proven: at any cost, failure-restricted policies are capped by the oracle gain on failing queries (8–57% uncapped). The other is empirical, replicated on three untouched corpora: failure scores rank helped queries far below failing ones, and reachability explains why: the gate sees the top of the ranking, while rescue depends on what lies below it. Whether a failure score still helps routing depends on how benefit varies with difficulty: on HotpotQA reranking helps hard queries most and failure routing pays; on the other five corpora it does not. Stronger predictors and probes helped only on NQ and HotpotQA. The lesson is not that pre-action telemetry is uninformative, but that failure accuracy does not measure its value.

Limitations. One small (3B) generator; reranking and PRF only under BM25, with one cross-encoder and one PRF family. Six corpora, four untouched; three (430, 648, 400 test queries) are underpowered for differences below about 0.015; under dense retrieval, retriever strength and domain are confounded, and the dense QE labels include the reranker. TripClick's labels are click-derived and sparse. The cost weight κ is illustrative, latencies are single-machine (median, P95 check), and probes cover reranking only. All pre-committed results are reported.

11 Conclusion

QPP predicts whether a ranking is poor; selective retrieval needs to know whether an intervention helps. A controller acting only on failing queries gets at most 8–57% of the oracle's gain, a learned failure gate selects poorly even among them, and its score ranks helped queries far below failing ones, on three untouched corpora, because rescue depends on reachability it does not observe. Selective-intervention work should report benefit AUC, failure-only ceilings, and cost-aware routing curves, not only failure-detection AUC.

Ethical Considerations

All data (TripClick and BEIR NQ, ArguAna, FiQA, DBPedia-Entity, and HotpotQA) are existing research benchmarks used under their licenses; TripClick is used for non-commercial research, and no model or per-query output fit on it is released. TripClick's click logs are aggregate, de-identified interactions, and we make no attempt to re-identify searchers. No human-subjects data was collected. The generator is a small, locally hosted model used only to rewrite queries within a bounded action space. Our central finding cautions against deploying generative interventions on the strength of a failure detector alone.

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